Wanna Get Hyped?: A Look into the Collaboration Album Between Worldwide Popstars of SEVENTEEN

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The product examined is the SEVENTEEN new unit album, 'HYPE VIBES,' a collaboration between members S. Coups (Choi Seung Cheol) and Mingyu (Kim Min-Gyu) under the name CxM. Since debuting under PLEDIS Entertainment in 2015, SEVENTEEN has become known for its self-produced music and ability to translate authentic friendship into artistic expression. Released in September 2025, HYPE VIBES showcases this same dynamic through an album centered on the energy of youth and the freedom of fun (Kwak, 2025). For this analysis, the focus lies on the physical album copies for purchase, which include the CD, photobook, stickers, lyric book, posters, and the highly anticipated photocards: all physical contributions central to the distinctive characteristics of K-pop's participatory fan culture.

These inclusions go beyond simple merchandise. The photocard, for example, acts as a social token that turns ownership into connection: fans meet to trade, display them in phone cases/on handbags, and signal belonging to a shared community. Stickers, posters, and photobooks serve a similar purpose by allowing fans to personalize objects and exchange "freebies"[1] at concerts. Even the album versions, named Buddy and Combi, emphasize the main theme of companionship and togetherness. The product thus links its physical attributes (A) to social consequences (C) and underlying values (V) of friendship and a care-free lifestyle, aligning with the means-end framework (Reynolds & Gutman, 1988).

An open-ended laddering interview was conducted with a 22-year-old Female USC student who replied 'yes' when asked if familiar with SEVENTEEN. The interviewer posed the question of whether or not the participant had chosen to purchase a physical copy of the HYPE

1 A free gift given from one fan to another at a concert. Fans often utilize extra album inclusions to make crafts to gift other fans.

VIBES album, and probed after the participant confirmed she had. The process encouraged reflection on why she chose to buy the album and how it made her feel. Probing techniques, particularly Negative Laddering probes, such as “Why is that important to you?” and “What does that lead to for you?” guided her toward deeper-seeded values (Reynolds & Gutman, 1988). The interviewee explained that her SEVENTEEN bias[2] was Mingyu, and thus she felt much more inclined to tune into his activities away from the group as a whole. With only two members, her likelihood of receiving Mingyu content (posters, photocards, and photobook images) was higher, which increased purchase satisfaction and reduced the stress often tied to randomized pulls. She also found the unit release more financially manageable and laid-back than a full-group comeback, allowing her to complete her photocard collection more easily and feel more connected to the artist when focusing on just two members, as compared to the usual thirteen. Ultimately, her responses aligned with a desire for belonging, fun, and relaxation, all of which are values mirrored by the album’s central themes.

The existing advertisement, a 1 minute 41 seconds long video released on YouTube, employs a “day-in-the-life” format to follow the pair through a stylized day in Hollywood (Appendix B). It opens with the pair waking up after a party, then flashes through scenes of shopping, alcohol, dancing, and ending the day partying at the beach all over again. Lively visuals, fast cut editing style, and ending with the slogan “Wanna get hyped? CxM here now!” promotes an image of daily carefree luxury. The ad successfully conveys the values (V) of friendship and escape from the stresses of daily life identified in the HVM (Appendix A), but fails to address the consequence (C) of connection central to fans’ personal experiences with the album’s physical attributes (A). While it creates a sense of aspirational excitement, it showcases

2 Bias is a pop culture term which refers to a member of a group someone feels biased toward (favorite).

no trading, gifting, or shared participation, which are the actions that connect how fans and artists can actually “get hyped” together.

A new advertisement could bridge this gap by placing the album’s social values at the forefront. During SEVENTEEN’s current “NEW_ World Tour,” PLEDIS Entertainment could host a HYPE VIBES after-party at each concert, prompting fans to enter a raffle for a chance at entry. Winners would receive a free copy of the album and be filmed as they open it, trade photocards, and meet other fans to show buyers how they can use the product to fill the personal values it embodies. Clips from different countries on each tour stop also could be spliced together of each participant answering the prompt: “What gets you hype?” The montage would show how people worldwide interpret “hype” through their own cultural expressions (such as dancing, drinking games, laughter, and trading), emphasizing themes of connection and inclusion, before revealing S. Coups and Mingyu surprising the crowd to join the celebration themselves.

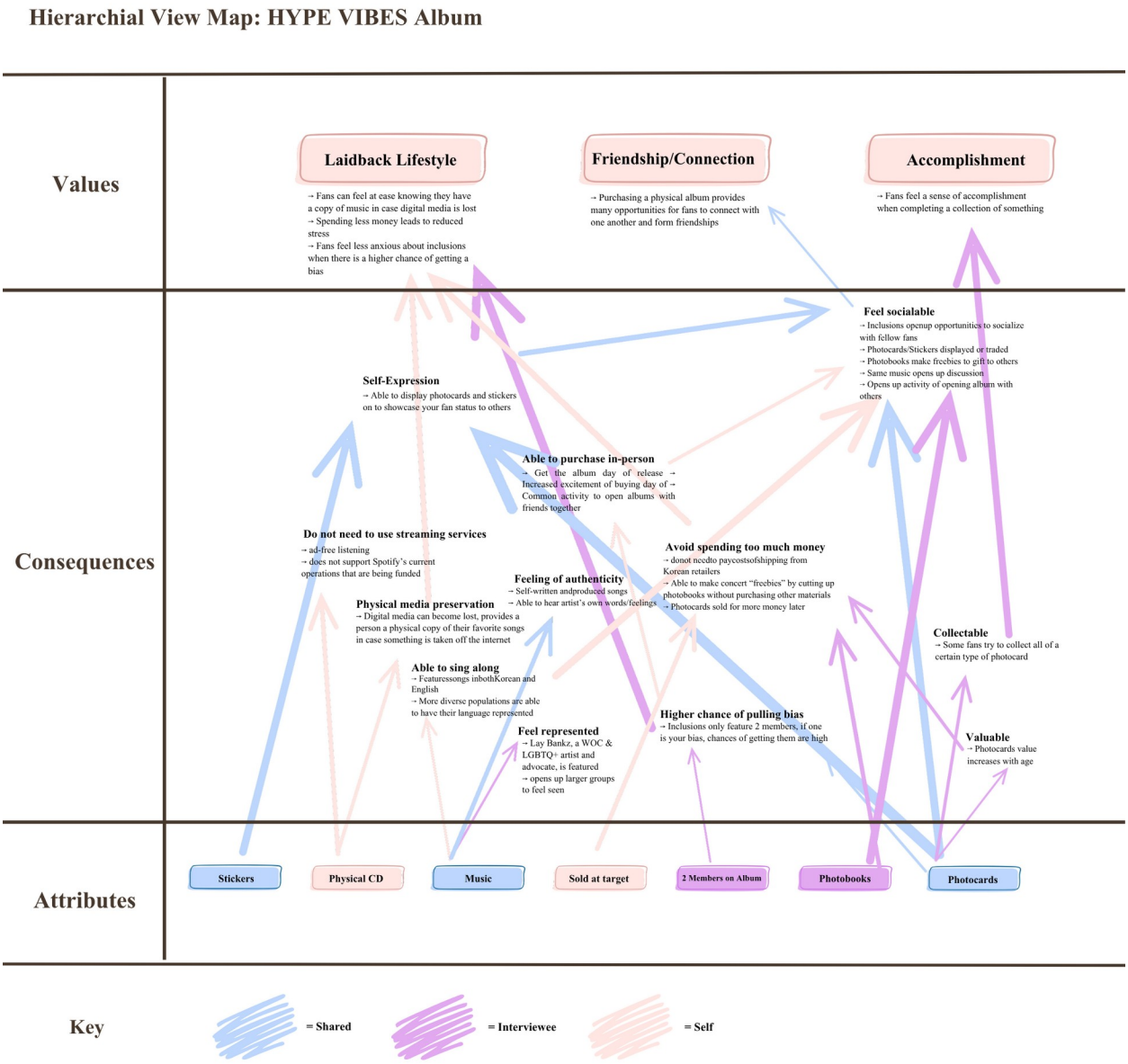
This campaign translates the product’s attributes (collectible items, photocard exchange) into tangible consequences (community interaction, sense of belonging) that materializes its values (connection, care-free & fun living). This erases the original ad’s limitations by making the depicted lifestyle accessible rather than idealized through the depiction of average fans utilizing the album. The artists’ presence at fan events also reframes them not as distant, glamorized celebrities but as participants in a shared culture of hype. Through this approach, CxM embodies the idea that hype is not just energy on stage but a feeling co-created between artists and fans across the world.

In the context of participant selection, there are definitely limitations into how this data can be utilized. The interviewee was somebody that already had prior knowledge of

SEVENTEEN, so the participant was someone who was more predisposed to have knowledge of the HYPE VIBES unit collaboration than someone who did not have prior knowledge of the group as a whole. As this interview was only conducted with one participant, there is an obvious lack of diversity in response samples which makes this data difficult to generalize across a population. To address these limitations and promote this study's validity, it would be helpful to conduct interviews across a much larger sample showcasing various demographics. This would likely result in data that could reflect a larger group of people more accurately.

Appendix

Appendix A: Hierarchical View Map



Appendix B: Link to existing 'HYPE VIBES' Advertisement

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=NkbjgNh06bQ

References

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